HackIndia 2026: AI-First Startup Hackathon

Comprehensive Event Brief, Clarifications & Winning Strategy

1. Executive Summary & Event Overview

The **HackIndia 2026: AI-First Startup Hackathon** challenges participants to build a fully functional startup prototype using an **AI-first workflow**. In this hackathon, AI is not merely an assistant or autocomplete feature—it acts as a **co-founder and primary builder.**

- **Event Name:** AI-First Startup Hackathon | Build a Startup Using AI Only
- **Host Platform:** HackIndia
- **Format:** Online / Hybrid (Virtual worldwide participation)
- **Timeline / Freeze:** Active September 1 – October 31, 2026
- **Team Size:** 1 to 6 members (Solo builders or teams)
- **Grand Prize**: $10,000 (in Sharp tokens) + Incubation Opportunity
- **Core Philosophy:** "Vibe Coding" & Agentic AI — using AI tools to replace traditional development workflows and build a viable product from zero to launch. The final web or mobile application must deliver core intelligence to the user via AI agents, LLM APIs, predictive models, or automated AI workflows.

2. Key Rules & Operational Mandates

1. **80%+ AI-Driven Execution:** At least 80% of the entire product (codebase, architecture, design, and market strategy) must be generated using AI tools (e.g., Cursor, Claude, Bolt.new, v0.dev, GitHub Copilot, Replit Agent).
2. **AI Transparency:** Teams must document their AI usage, prompts, and workflows in an AI Usage Report / README.
3. **Original Work**: All submissions must be newly created during the hackathon period

3. Mandatory Deliverables at Code Freeze

- **Public GitHub Repository**: Containing complete code and documentation.
- **Live Deployed Application:** A working URL (web, mobile, or deployed AI agent).
- **Demo Video:** A 3–5 minute video demonstrating product functionality and workflow.
- **Pitch Deck & AI Usage Report**: Highlighting business viability and AI orchestration.

3. Evaluation & Scoring Rubric

Criteria	Weight	What Judges Look For
AI-First Execution	**25%**	Deep, meaningful integration of AI as both the primary builder and the core product engine.
Product & Innovation	**20%**	Originality, solution depth, and effectiveness in solving a real-world problem.
Functionality & Execution	**20%**	Stability, UX/UI quality, live deployment reliability, and technical implementation.
Market Potential	**15%**	Business viability, market opportunity, target audience definition, and scalability.
AI Usage & Workflow	**10%**	Effective orchestration of AI agents, prompts, automated pipelines, and tools during development.
Demo & Pitch	**10%**	Clarity, narrative quality, video demonstration, and overall presentation.

4. Key Clarifications & Doubts Resolved

A. Clarifying "Vibe Coding" vs. "AI-First Product"

- **The Confusion:** *"Do I just use vibe coding tools to build a standard website for a real-world problem?"*
- **The Clarification:** Vibe coding is **how you build the app** (using tools like Cursor or Bolt.new instead of manual coding). However, the app itself **must also have AI capabilities inside it**. Building a standard static web app using AI code generation is not enough to score high on "AI-First Execution."

B. Startup vs. AI-First Startup

Feature	Traditional Startup / Standard Web App	AI-First Startup (HackIndia Standard)
Development	Written line-by-line manually.	80%+ generated using AI tools/prompts.
Core Engine	Database CRUD (Create, Read, Update, Delete) operations and manual forms.	**AI models and agents.** Without AI, the product cannot function or deliver value.
User Experience	User inputs data manually and clicks buttons.	**Autonomous & Agentic:** AI reasons through multi-step problems, auto-completes tasks, or generates custom outputs.

Value Creation	Organizes information or facilitates transactions manually.	Solves problems using dynamic intelligence, RAG, custom agents, or fine-tuned LLMs.

C. How to Ensure Your Project Qualifies as "AI-First"

Ask yourself this **acid test question**:
"If I completely remove all AI APIs, LLM models, and Agent workflows from my finished app, does it still function as a complete solution, or does it become an empty shell?"

- **If it still works fine without AI:** It is a standard web app with an AI add-on. (Low AI score)
- **If it completely breaks or loses its core value without AI:** It is a true **AI-First Startup**. (High AI score)

5. What NOT to Do (Pitfalls to Avoid)

1. **Don't Hand-Code More Than 20%:** Avoid writing standard code line-by-line out of habit. Let AI generators do the heavy lifting while you direct, prompt, and debug.
2. **Don't Just Build a "Static" Website:** Ensure your app interacts with real AI backend services (e.g., OpenAI API, Anthropic, LangChain, n8n, local models).
3. **Don't Forget to Submit a Live URL:** Submitting only a GitHub repo or a localhost recording will result in lower scores. Use Vercel, Netlify, or Render for live hosting.
4. **Don't Treat It Like an Academic Assignment:** Frame your presentation as a real startup. Include target market analysis, revenue models, and scalability strategy.
5. **Don't Hide Your AI Usage:** Document your prompts, agent workflows, and dev process in your project's README.md. Include clear prompt logs, system architecture diagrams, and pipeline descriptions in your repository to prove 80%+ AI generation.

6. Hackathon Tracks

Participants can choose one of the following startup tracks:

1. **AI SaaS Startup:** Build a SaaS product powered by AI
2. **AI for Healthcare**: Diagnostics, wellness, or patient experience
3. **AI FinTech**: Payments, fraud detection, trading tools
4. **AI for Educatio**n: Learning platforms, skill assessment
5. **AI in any startup:** Climate, productivity, accessibility, or any other idea outside of the above tracks is acceptable

6. Key Strategies to Win the Hackathon

A. Prove "AI-First" Mastery (25% Weight)
B. Deliver a 100% Functional, Live Product (20% Weight)
C. Emphasize "Startup Viability" Over "Hackathon Project" (15% Weight)

D. Master the Demo Video & Pitch (10% Weight)

The 3–5 Minute Rule: Keep your demo video crisp.

- **0:00 - 0:45:** The Problem & Solution Statement.
- **0:45 - 2:30:** Live Walkthrough of the Deployed Product.
- **2:30 - 3:30:** Behind the Scenes (How AI built it & System Architecture).
- **3:30 - End:** Market Opportunity, Business Model & Future Roadmap.

E. Pick High-Impact Domains

Focus on areas with high current demand for autonomous agentic solutions:

- Vertical SaaS & Productivity Automation
- Healthcare & Life Sciences Data Synthesis
- FinTech & Automated Risk/Trading Analysis
- Developer Tools & Agentic Frameworks

7. Recommended Tech Stack

- **AI App Development & Vibe Coding:** Cursor, Claude 3.5 Sonnet, v0.dev, Bolt.new, GitHub Copilot.
- **Agentic Workflows & AI Backend:** LangChain, LlamaIndex, CrewAI, n8n, AutoGen, OpenAI/Anthropic APIs.
- **Frontend & Database:** Next.js / React (TailwindCSS) + Supabase / Firebase / Postgres.
- **Hosting & Deployment:** Vercel, Netlify, Render, Railway.

8. OUR END RESULT SHOULD BE:

- Innovative
- Usable
- Impactful in Quantitative and Qualitative manner
- Solving Real World problem
- Helps in reducing human efforts.
- Irresistible to use (Optional)
- Generate money for the use.